

My Data Body

Marilène Oliver
University of Alberta
Canada
marilene@ualberta.ca

Stephan Moore
Northwestern University
United States of America
stephan@northwestern.edu

Scott Smallwood
University of Alberta
Canada
ssmallwo@ualberta.ca

J.R. Carpenter
Independent
United Kingdom
carpenter@luckysoap.com

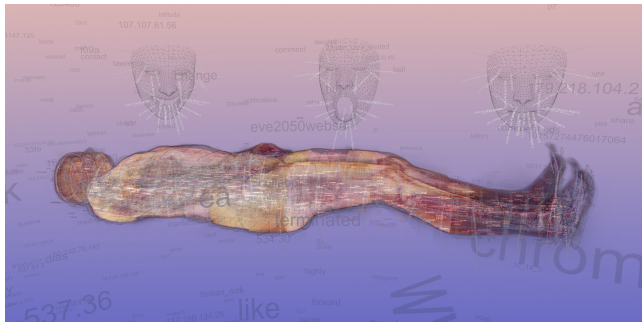
ACM Reference Format:

Marilène Oliver, Scott Smallwood, Stephan Moore, and J.R. Carpenter. 2022. My Data Body. In *Proceedings of the ACM SIGGRAPH '22 Art Gallery*, August 07-11, 2022, Vancouver, BC, Canada. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 2 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3532837.3534953>

1 PROJECT URL

<https://www.knowthyself.ualberta.ca/my-data-body/>

2 DESCRIPTION OF ARTWORK



In *My Data Body*, the magnetic resonance (MR) scanned body of the artist Marilène Oliver floats prone within a ‘cloud’ of her textual Facebook data. Into the semi-transparent, virtual body are multiple other data corpuses downloaded from social media platforms plotted into cross sections of the body. In the horizontal plane, Mac terminal data is plotted into bone, Google data into muscle and Facebook data into fat. In the vertical plane are plotted data usage agreements. Passwords and logins flow back and forth through veins and arteries, whilst retinal images, dental scans and 3D meshes of organs and bones are suspended within the quantified and datafied body [Lupton 2016; Van Dijk 2014]. There is a continuous stream of text particles that flow through and around the data body that one can swat away or nestle into.

Permission to make digital or hard copies of part or all of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

SIGGRAPH '22 Art Gallery, August 07-11, 2022, Vancouver, BC, Canada

© 2022 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-9372-0/22/08.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3532837.3534953>



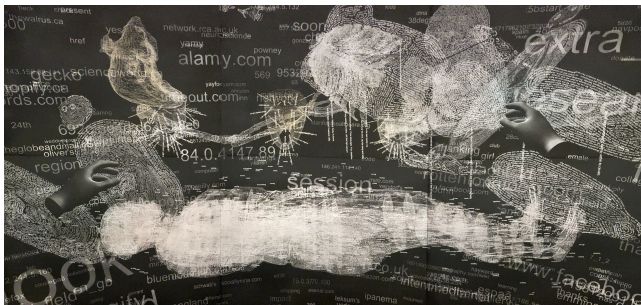
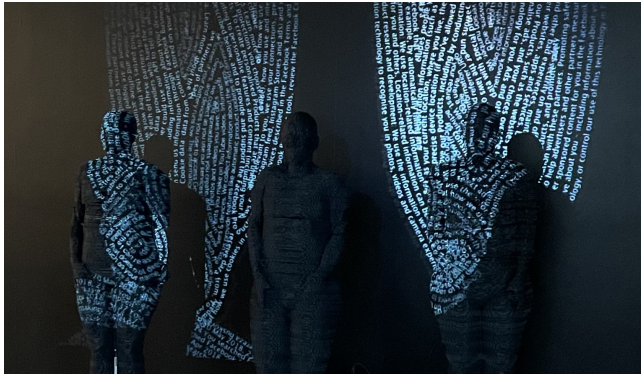
Via technological prosthesis of the controllers and headset [Diodato 2012; Hansen 2006], the body of the user can fly around *My Data Body*, clip away the scan data, pull out and read the text slices. They can also extract organs and bones, some of which have mini text clouds emanating from them or contents that can be ‘poured’. The brain cascades login windows and the heart spills emojis. Each of the bones has poetic text attached to it. *My Data Body* can be dissected and reassembled as a unique composition. After a certain period of time however, the extracted slices, organs and bones float back to their original location, much like satellites returning to a space station. Recalling the 1966 film *The Fantastic Voyage* [Fleischer 1966], the viewer can enlarge *My Data Body* so that they are engulfed by it or shrink it and hold it miniscule in their virtual hands.

To echo historical public anatomical dissections, there is an audience circling the body of the artist’s facial recognition scans wearing different emotions. Recalling myths of nuns performing dissections in order to find evidence of saintliness [Park 1994], the artist’s ‘SIN’ (social insurance number) is pinned to their coccyx. This deeply hidden digital ‘SIN’ recalls contemporary online cancel culture where a single post or tweet has the ability to demonize the author forever. The *My Data Body* dissection theatre is bathed in a blend of volcano ash lavender [Bridle 2018] and forest fire orange in order to evoke the fears and fantasies associated with the immense amounts of energy needed to generate and process data and its direct impact on climate change [Mullaney et al. 2021].

Each of the elements in *My Data Body*: the scan data, organs, bones, cross sections can be extracted and inspected individually elsewhere in the scene. Each object has an accompanying sound, which is revealed only when it is grasped and removed from the body. The soundscape by Scott Smallwood and Stephan Moore is

a culminating mixture of these objects, in whatever configuration they are placed in by the user. They incorporate biometric digital recordings of the artist's voice and heartbeat as well as textural and other sounds (including scratching and scribbling on wood, gurglings, squelchings and resonances) attached to each element so that as *My Data Body* is dissected visually and spatially, it is also 'de/re-composed' sonically. Indeed, the sound composition is only created as bones, organs and slices are extracted.

Poetic text written by J.R Carpenter flows through and dangles from *My Data Body*. The poet composed lines of verse for each of the bones so that when the bones are pulled out of the body the text can be rotated and read. From the ribcage for example hang the phrases: *I dream I hear a body sleeping, in the bed beside me. But it's only the wind, big ribs rising and falling. It's only the house, breathing through its nose. Pasted into the back of the retinal scans are the words: (I cannot imagine a mark on my body any deeper than the memory of text burned into my retina, left smouldering in my brain).* The lyrical text interrupts the informational, blurring boundaries between the data body and the embodied, societal structures it inhabits.



3 ARTIST INFORMATION

Marilène Oliver is an assistant professor of printmaking at the University of Alberta, Canada. Oliver has exhibited internationally in both private and public galleries including the Victoria and Albert Museum, The Wellcome Trust (UK), MassMoCA, Knoxville Museum of Art (USA) Frissarias Museum (Greece), Casino Luxembourg (Luxembourg), Fundació Sorigué (Spain) and The Glenbow Museum (Canada).

Scott Smallwood is a sound artist, composer, and performer who creates works inspired by discovered textures and forms,

through a practice of listening, field recording, and improvisation. He performs as one-half of the laptop/electronic duo Evidence (with Stephan Moore) and teaches as an associate professor of composition at the University of Alberta, where he also serves as the director of the Sound Studies Institute.

Stephan Moore is a sound artist, designer, composer, improviser, programmer, engineer, teacher, and curator based in Chicago. He is the curator of sound art for the Caramoor Center for Music and the Arts, organizing annual exhibitions since 2014. In 2019, he co-founded the Chicago Laboratory for Electro-Acoustic Theater to promote and encourage the creation of multichannel audio works. He is a Distinguished Associate Professor of Instruction in the Sound Arts and Industries program at Northwestern University.

J. R. Carpenter is a UK-based artist, writer, performer, and researcher working across performance, print, and digital media. She is a winner of the CBC Quebec Writing Competition, the QWF Carte Blanche Quebec Award, Expozine Alternative Press Award and the New Media Writing Prize. She is a Fellow of the Eccles Centre For North American Studies at the British Library.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

My Data Body was made with the research assistance of Kirtan Shah, Walter Ostrander, Chelsey Campbell, Jiayi Ye and benefited greatly from the expertise of the whole KTVR research team. The project has been supported by the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada and the Kule Institute of Advanced Studies, University of Alberta.

REFERENCES

- James Bridle. 2018. *New dark age: Technology and the end of the future*. Verso Books, London, UK.
- Roberto Diodato. 2012. *Aesthetics of the Virtual*. State University of New York Press, New York, USA.
- Richard Fleischer. 1966. *Fantastic Voyage*.
- Mark Hansen. 2006. *Bodies in Code: Interfaces with Digital Media*. Routledge, New York, USA.
- Deborah Lupton. 2016. *The Quantified Self*. Polity, Malden, MA, USA.
- Thomas Mullaney, Benjamin Peters, Mar Hicks, and Kavita Philip. 2021. *Your Computer is on Fire*. MIT Press, Cambridge, USA.
- Katharine Park. 1994. The Criminal and the Saintly Body: Autopsy and Dissection in Renaissance Italy. *Renaissance Quarterly* 47, 1 (1994), 1–33.
- José Van Dijck. 2014. Datafication, Dataism and Dataveillance: Big Data Between Scientific Paradigm and Ideology. *Surveillance & society* 12, 2 (2014), 197–208.